

Steve Blank

Customer Development & Getting Out of the Building

b. 1953 · Serial entrepreneur & educator · Stanford, Berkeley, Columbia

[portrait]
Steve Blank

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Blank's insight sounds obvious but changed everything: a startup is a search for a business model, so go and test it with customers. His customer-development method underpins the solution interviews and validation logic of Units 8 and 9.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

American serial entrepreneur and educator who founded or worked in eight startups before turning to teaching. He created the customer-development methodology and the Lean LaunchPad course, seeding the Lean Startup movement Ries later popularised.

"There are no facts inside your building, so get outside."

"A startup is a temporary organization designed to search for a repeatable, scalable business model."

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Customer Development	Search, don't just execute, a business model
Get out of the building	Test assumptions with real customers
Four steps to the epiphany	Discovery · validation · creation · building
Business model vs plan	A startup searches; a company executes
Lean LaunchPad	Evidence-based entrepreneurship pedagogy

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Treat every business-plan assumption as a hypothesis
- Interview real customers before building
- Run customer discovery then validation in sequence
- Distinguish searching from executing a model
- Use solution interviews to test problem-solution fit

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Interview-based evidence can mislead if poorly run
- Method assumes accessible, identifiable customers
- Less guidance for deep-tech with long discovery
- Can be applied as ritual rather than genuine inquiry
- Search framing under-emphasises execution capability

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- Originated customer development and the lean movement
- Shaped modern evidence-based entrepreneurship teaching
- Lean LaunchPad adopted by NSF and universities worldwide
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Units 8 and 9 validation
- *Four Steps to the Epiphany* a foundational startup text

SELECTED WORKS

THE FOUR STEPS TO THE EPIPHANY

Successful Strategies for Products That Win

BLANK · 2005

THE STARTUP OWNER'S MANUAL

with Bob Dorf

BLANK & DORF · 2012

WHY THE LEAN START-UP CHANGES EVERYTHING

Harvard Business Review

BLANK · 2013

HOLDING A CAT BY THE TAIL

Lessons from startups

BLANK · 2014

REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

- Blank, S. (2013) 'Why the Lean Start-Up Changes Everything', *Harvard Business Review*, 91(5), pp. 63–72.
- Blank, S. and Dorf, B. (2012) *The Startup Owner's Manual*. Pescadero, CA: K&S Ranch.